

chapter 10



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topic selection and audience analysis

When you have read and thought about this chapter, you will be able to

1. Select a topic appropriate for you and your audience.
2. Practice narrowing a topic to save time and energy and increase its relevance to the audience.
3. Analyze your audience through observation, inference, research, and questionnaires.
4. Adapt your topic, yourself, your language, and your purpose for an audience.

How do you choose what to speak about? Many speakers get stuck on this first step in creating a speech and spend way too much time trying to decide on a topic. They have too many choices and cannot settle on just one. So this chapter will help you to more quickly determine what topics are important to you and to your audience, how to more rapidly narrow the focus so you do not waste time by exploring too many avenues, and how to accurately analyze the audience to make sure they will care about what you have to say. Your ability to effectively inform or persuade an audience rests on your skill in selecting an appropriate topic and in adapting that topic to the particular audience. Once you have mastered these skills for your classroom audience, you can apply them at work and in the community.

Stephen Bonsi, an international student from West Africa, was truly surprised when he did not earn a higher grade on his persuasive speech, but his story reveals the importance of topic selection and audience analysis.

Stephen did some things right. He loved politics and economics, so he had a vital topic. He was engaged in some protests over wealth inequality, so he had interest and commitment. He knew much about economics, so his speech was loaded with details about “waves of regulations,” “financial time bombs,” and “huge mortgage derivatives.” He pitted Wall



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Street against Main Street and waxed eloquent about the pitfalls of joblessness. Moreover, his persuasive purpose was an action goal of urging his audience to join the protest movement against the top 1% in wealth. But Stephen had trouble with topic selection and audience analysis.

His audience, about 20 students from nearly as many different programs, knew practically nothing about economics, cared little about politics, and were the opposite of activist. They had more immediate things to worry about: paying for school, keeping a job, caring for kids, and paying for food and lodging. More importantly, Stephen’s speech went way over their heads. He knew so much about economics and politics that little of what he said was actually understood. A speech that would have been a hit in a room full of political activists who knew more about economics was a failure in this particular classroom.

Have you ever had a similar experience? What could Stephen have done to choose a more appropriate topic and adapt it to his audience? What would you suggest? At the end of the chapter, we’ll take another look at Stephen’s situation.

You can skillfully avoid being a failure with your presentation just by learning about the basics of topic selection and audience analysis, two concepts that are bonded in any successful presentation. In this chapter you will learn some quick and effective ways to arrive at a topic without wasting time and effort. You will also learn how to size up your audience so you successfully inform and persuade them.

How to Select a Topic Appropriate for You and Your Audience

Finding a topic that is right for you and for your audience can be a challenge. Some speakers spend far too little time finding a suitable topic and end up speaking on something that audience members cannot connect with; others spend too long searching for topics, get forced into making a last-minute decision, and sacrifice valuable preparation time. Although you should devote adequate attention to thoughtful topic selection, this step should require only a small amount of your speech preparation time. This section explores some strategies for making an efficient and effective choice, beginning with two ways to quickly generate a list of ideas.

brainstorming

A creative procedure for thinking of as many topics as you can in a limited time.

USE BRAINSTORMING

Brainstorming consists of thinking of as many topics as you can in a limited time so you can select one that will be appropriate for you and your audience. Individual brainstorming (brainstorming by yourself as opposed to in a group) can be an effective way to find a topic for your public speech, reports, and term papers. Selecting a topic from a list of many that you've generated through brainstorming can be much easier than trying to think of just one perfect idea.

You'll find individual brainstorming to be relatively quick and easy. First, give yourself a limited time—say, five minutes—and without trying to think of titles or even complete thoughts, write down as many potential topics as you can. When your time is up, you should have a rough list of possible ideas or topics for your speech. Repeat this step if you want an even larger list.

Second, select the *three* items from your list that are the most appealing to you as topics for your speech. Third, from those three topics choose the *one* you think would be most appealing to both you and your audience. An alternate strategy, which we look at next, is to target your own interests as possible topics.

SURVEY YOUR INTERESTS

Public speaking starts with the self—with what you know, have experienced, or are willing to learn. Self-analysis can help you uncover the areas in which you are qualified to speak.

To survey your interests, consider the following:

- What you like best and least at work, about family life, about your community, and about our government, politics, and policies
- What causes take up your time and energy: your religion, your political party, and your position on important current issues
- What particular issues bother you personally that you want to bring to the attention of others: discrimination, environmental concerns, and healthcare
- What YouTube videos, TED Talks, or blogs you view have focused on

How do you select from among the topics that emerge through your brainstorming or a survey of your interests? First consider what you know and how you feel about the topic.

ASSESS YOUR KNOWLEDGE OF THE TOPIC

Once you have established that your topic is interesting to you and to your audience, you need to determine what you and your audience know about the subject. You are in the best position if you know more about the topic than does your audience. You can also

building behaviors

Using the Internet to Increase Your Knowledge of the Topic

You can find information about any topic by using Google or another search engine and appropriate key words. Table 1 lists examples of a few sources on just two topic areas—health and politics. Choose two or three sites that look interesting to you, go to those sites, and see if you can find and write down in your notebook one surprising fact that you learn from each of the sites. Your reason for doing this exercise all on your own is to demonstrate your skill in finding information and determining which information is worth telling others.

To find specific information and some unique sources for your topic, take a close look at blog sites. You can find them by doing an Internet search for “blog directory.” Select a particular area—for instance, “environment”—and you will usually find hundreds of blog sites that reveal specific information about topics such as “living green.” Take care to evaluate the information you find in blogs—some blogs are more reliable than others and better at revealing the source of material presented as fact. And, as always, remember to reveal in your speech where you found your information.

Table 1 Internet Sources for Health and Politics

HEALTH	
www.cnn.com/HEALTH/	Information on diet, fitness, and parenting; special feature: video clips
www.webmd.com/	Health and medical news and information
www.healthfinder.gov/	Health and human services from the U.S. government; special feature: leads to online publications
POLITICS	
www.factcheck.org/	A website sponsored by the Annenberg Public Policy Center to check on the accuracy of political statements in ads, debates, and speeches
www.cnn.com/POLITICS/	Cable News Network's political section, a middle-of-the-road, national perspective
www.nytimes.com/pages/politics/index.html	News, opinions, and multimedia about political campaigns and elections from an East Coast, liberal perspective
www.latimes.com/news/politics/	Political news and information on elected officials and candidates with an emphasis on West Coast and national government
www.politico.com/	A widely respected website on politics from D.C.

add to what you know by talking to others, reading, and visiting websites on the subject. Let's say you really think that something a politician said was far from true, yet you hear classmates saying the same untrue statement. You can check up on the truth or accuracy of a politician's speech by going to a fact-check website like the ones in table 1.

EVALUATE YOUR COMMITMENT TO THE TOPIC

Even a topic about which you're well informed is not a good choice for a presentation unless you feel some commitment to it. **Commitment** is a measure of how much time and effort you put into a cause. For example, you know many children are waiting to be adopted; you deeply want more people to be concerned about heart disease and cancer because your relatives died from these diseases; or you want less government interference in our personal lives. You spend time and effort on what you care about, so those causes can guide you to select an ideal topic for you and your audience.

commitment
A measure of how much time and effort you put into a cause; your passion and concern about the topic.

Be aware, however, that commitment to a topic may not be enough to overcome poor preparation. A study exploring whether commitment to a topic is related to speech performance found it was not—the strongest predictor of speech performance is actually the work put into preparation.¹ Although you may need to be committed to a topic to put in adequate preparation for a speech, commitment may not be enough to help you deliver an effective presentation.

CONSIDER THE AGE OF THE TOPIC AND OF THE AUDIENCE

Topics, like people, live, change, and die—some have long and varied lives, whereas others pass on quickly. You will want to consider the age and development of your subject matter, as well as the age and development of your audience. Some topics have endured for decades, if not centuries:

- How much should government be allowed to intervene in our lives?
- Should the United States use military force to promote democracy?
- What can and should we do for the poor and marginalized in our society?
- What can and should we do about the privileged and overrewarded in our society?
- Should concern for the environment limit our exploration for oil?

Even very young people have probably heard plenty about many long-standing issues, although more mature audiences, including returning college students, are likely to have more sophisticated ideas about them. Younger audiences may have less hardened positions, however. What all this means is that groups of different ages can be treated differently. You will also want to treat mature topics in new ways, not just rehash what the audience has heard repeatedly in the past. The effective presenter takes into account both the age of the issue and the age of the audience and skillfully adapts the topic to the particular audience for maximum effect.

In fact, here are some suggestions that can keep you on track to success because violating these three suggestions has resulted in poor evaluations for students who ignore them.

1. Stick to vital topics; do not select a trivial topic. You might find fascinating the making of a leather belt, but the topic is neither vital nor necessarily of interest to a general audience.
2. Beware of overused topics—unless you have a novel approach. Gun control and abortion are important topics, but unless you have something new to offer, your teacher and your audience may be bored by hearing more on the topic.
3. Do not demonstrate with visual resources that are banned on campus, such as firearms, illegal drugs, and alcohol.

We turn next from commitment and avoidable topics to determining your audience's interest in a topic.

DETERMINE YOUR TOPIC'S IMPORTANCE TO YOUR AUDIENCE

Once you have selected a possible topic, evaluate whether it is important to your audience. First, you have the advantage of hearing every speech your classmates deliver, so their topic selections give you a good idea of what they think are important subjects. Second, you are in a college context where important issues arise about student rights and the costs of tuition, books, food, and lodging; and often guest speakers come on campus to address issues of interest to college students. Third, your college exists in a community where issues occur between town and gown: noise ordinances, parking restrictions, housing and zoning regulations, slumlords, and overpriced housing. Fourth, you can be among the few who actually know about the larger context to national and international issues that can affect students whether they know it or not. So you can be among the first to warn them of issues such as recessions, employment trends, interest rates, and new legislation that will affect them now or in the near future. The importance of a topic, then, can be as close to home as another student's speech or as far as financial failure in a distant land, as long as you can relate that topic by demonstrating its importance to your audience.

TOPIC SELECTION FOR ENGLISH LANGUAGE LEARNERS

Topic selection can be even more challenging for students who are English language learners (ELLs) because different cultures may have quite different norms about what may be discussed in public, about the appropriate use and meaning of silence or long pauses, and about the desirability of looking at your audience when you speak. In this section we provide various suggestions for non-native speakers to keep in mind when selecting a topic.

1. *Draw on personal experience.* Because U.S. culture values individuality, people's unique personal experiences are often viewed as important layers of an explanation or argument, and U.S. speakers are usually quite comfortable about

revealing personal experiences to an audience. You may or may not be as comfortable talking about yourself, but while you should also use other types of support to document your speech, selecting a topic with which you have personal experience, and therefore credibility, is often wise.

2. *Review many sample topics.* To get a sense of what types of topics other students are likely to select, review as many sample topics as possible, using this edition of *Human Communication*, resources from your library, and an Internet search for “speech topics.” You can then adapt your own topic ideas to be consistent with these samples in scope, focus, and viewpoint if necessary.
3. *Consult with your instructor.* Your instructor is your most valuable resource for topic selection. The best approach is to brainstorm three to five topic ideas and meet with your instructor to discuss the advantages and disadvantages of each. You should also talk to your instructor about how to appropriately narrow your chosen topic.
4. *Remember that smaller is better.* If reading material quickly is difficult for you, you might benefit from selecting topics that are narrower in focus. Narrower topics are easier to research and probably easier to organize. Better to talk about only the ecology of the Amazon River than to try to discuss the environment of all of Brazil.

Practice Narrowing Your Topic

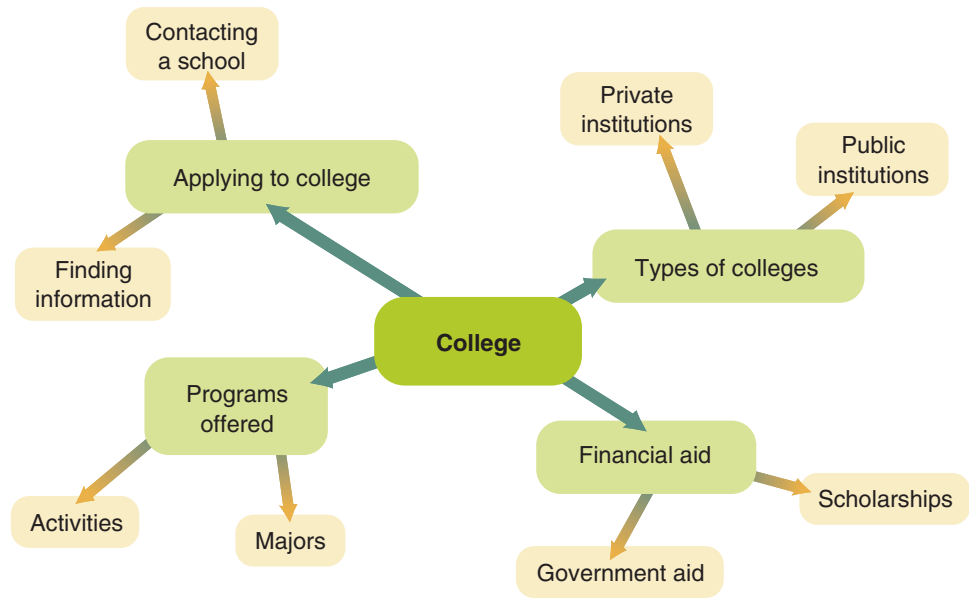
Even after thinking about their topic’s importance and their own knowledge and commitment, beginning presenters often select a topic that is too large for their time limit. Ending animal cruelty, buying a car, and overcoming an addiction may meet the requirements of importance, knowledge, and commitment, but they are too broad. They will produce hundreds of sources on the Internet, giving you much more information than you can manage. If you take the time to carefully narrow a topic *before* you begin your search for additional information, you can save much time and even more frustration. Figure 1 shows concept mapping, one way to narrow your topic.

Another way to narrow a topic is to take a broad and even abstract category, such as music, and list as many smaller topics as you can that are at least loosely related to it:

- The development of country/western music
- The influence of Les Paul on rock and blues
- Rap artists
- Music therapy
- The history of Parkour
- Elementary music education
- The history of the electric guitar
- Hip-hop artists as role models

Extend your list of more specific and concrete topics until you have a large number from which to choose.

How will you know when your topic is narrow enough? Consider (1) the amount of information available about it, (2) the amount of information you can convey within the time limits for the speech, and (3) whether you can discuss the topic in enough depth to keep audience members interested.



A student can narrow a speech topic down by using an approach called *concept mapping*. Starting with the general topic of college, she is able to visually identify four subtopics: applying to college, types of colleges, programs offered, and financial aid. Each subtopic is further broken down into more specific areas. Visually mapping the topic-narrowing step in this way can help you see important dimensions of a particular topic area as well as connections between several dimensions of the topic.

Figure 1

Selecting and narrowing a topic.

Still another approach is to look at the examples of successful topics in table 2. These topics are called “successful” because they have currency, they are related to some issues of national importance, and they are relatively easy to link to listeners’ interests. For example, the topic “Ditch Your Bank” is a national issue that can easily affect people in your audience. When federal legislation lowered bank profits by limiting how much banks can charge merchants for customers who use debit cards, the banks struck back by trying and sometimes failing to impose other fees, such as a fee for having a checking account.² People responded so negatively that some of the biggest U.S. banks had to back off their decision and rescind the new fees.³ But other fees for not using your account, for using a teller, for requesting a canceled check, or for using an ATM remain. So, the “Ditch Your Bank” topic is current and relates directly to anyone who uses a bank. The other topics on the list are similarly related to current concerns and linked to audience interests.

Table 2 Possible Presentation Topics

Ditch Your Bank	Successful Job Hunting
Foodborne Illnesses	Keeping Drugs Out of Sports
Pawn with Care	Beware of Paycheck Loans
Why Tuition Keeps Rising	Costs of Insurance

Analyze Your Audience

Audience analysis is the collection and interpretation of audience characteristics through observation, inference, research, and questionnaires. Why should you analyze your audience? Especially, why should you analyze an audience of classmates?

Suppose you are giving a speech arguing that a state should not take away an individual's right to belong to a union. To give an effective presentation, you should know not only state law (some states prohibit unions by denying workers the right to strike) but also how most of the individuals in your audience feel about unionization. If they agree with your view, you will probably take a different persuasive approach than if they disagree. If you plan to inform audience members about the use of performance-enhancing drugs in sports, you will want to know whether any of them have played organized sports, because this activity might have given them personal experience of such drugs, which will influence their attitudes about your information. In both cases you must use audience analysis to learn about your audience members' beliefs and backgrounds; such information will be invaluable as you select, focus, and narrow your topic.

Audience analysis for public speaking is similar to target marketing in advertising and public relations. The process can be as simple as “eyeballing” a group to estimate age, sex, and race or as complicated as polling a group of people to discover their feelings on your topic. The insights you gain about the people to whom you speak will ensure that your speech is as effective as possible.

Next we examine four methods of analyzing an audience. They are based on your observations of the audience, your inferences, your research, and your questions and their answers.

OBSERVATION

Effective public speakers must engage in active observation, using their senses of sight, hearing, smell, and touch to build information about their audience. An effective lawyer observes jurors' verbal and nonverbal behavior and decides which arguments, evidence, and witnesses are influencing them. Activists and fund-raisers have usually spent years watching others and learning which approaches, arguments, and evidence are most likely to be accepted by an audience.

You can learn to observe your class. For every speech you give, you might listen to 20 or 25 given by others, each of which gives you a unique opportunity to discover your classmates' responses. Do they respond well to speakers who come on strong or to speakers who talk to them as equals? Do they like speeches about work, leisure, or ambition? Do they respond well to numbers and statistics, stories and examples, graphs and posters, or PowerPoint and Prezi? Even though your classroom audience may not have gathered just to hear you, you have an advantage over most public speakers: after all, how many of them have had the opportunity to hear every one of their listeners give a speech? Your classmates' responses to a variety of speakers, topics, and visual resources will give you a rich base of information about this audience, which you can use to your advantage when it is your turn to speak.

audience analysis

The collection and interpretation of audience information obtained by observation, inference, research, and questionnaires.

building behaviors

Sizing Up Your Audience

Some people are much better than others at sizing up an audience. Check out your own skill at analyzing an audience by inferring audience characteristics. For example, what is the approximate range in age, what cultures are represented, how many individuals wear attire or symbols that indicate their religion, how many wear athletic jackets and letters, do any have the names of fraternities or sororities on their clothing, and do any wear uniforms that indicate armed forces or the kind of work they do? Perhaps your instructor will allow you to check the accuracy of your inferences if classmates are willing to reveal some of this information.

inference

A tentative generalization based on some evidence.

indirect inference

A tentative generalization based on observation.

direct inference

A tentative generalization based on deliberately gathered data.

INFERENCE

To draw an **inference** is to make a tentative generalization based on some evidence. We infer from a man's wedding band that he is married, and from the children tugging at his sleeve that he is a father. We infer that the woman holding his arm is his wife. We are basing these inferences on thin data, but they are probably (though not infallibly) correct. The more evidence on which an inference is based, the more likely it is to be accurate.

You can base inferences on the observed characteristics of your audience, on demographic information, and on information obtained from questionnaires (discussed later in this section). An **indirect inference** is one we draw by observation. You might, for example, find that most of the students at a particular college hold part-time jobs (an observation). You might further infer that the school is expensive, that financial aid is limited, or that the cost of area housing is high. You might also infer, from your limited information, that most of the students in this school value their education, are exceptionally well motivated, or believe in saving money.

A **direct inference** is based on deliberately gathered data. You could, for example, ask either orally or in writing how many students in the class have part- or full-time jobs; how many are married, have families, and/or have grown children; how many plan to become wealthy; whether they were raised in an urban or a rural setting; and how many have strong religious ties. The answers to these questions provide valuable information about your audience. If you plan to deliver a presentation encouraging your audience to join the armed forces, your teacher will likely allow you to ask your classroom full of listeners how many of them have been deployed, have close relatives in the military, or plan to serve in the armed forces someday. Their answers to a simple question or two will certainly give you a head start on informing or persuading them.

RESEARCH ON YOUR AUDIENCE

When speaking outside the classroom, you can improve your chances of success by carefully researching your audience. That research can include inside informants, others who belong to the group, and an organization's website. Often the best inside informant is the person who invited you to speak to a group. Because you are a successful athlete, a high school asks you to speak at its annual athletic awards banquet. You will want to know from the person who invited you who is going to be in the audience (athletes only, or their parents and friends as well?), where the presentation is going to occur (in a crowded gym, a hotel banquet room?), how long you are expected to speak, and what they would like you to talk about. Similarly if you are asked to speak to a service club, such as Rotary, Kiwanis, or the Lions, you need to ask similar questions.

In addition, you will want to research the organization. Rotary International, for example, is very proud of its efforts to eradicate polio worldwide, Kiwanis is committed to changing the world one child and one community at a time, and the Lions are dedicated to solving vision problems around the globe. All three serve others, so your speech about any theme related to helping others is welcome at their meetings. Fortunately, the Internet has made your task of researching your audience much easier because most business, social, and religious groups have websites that detail their purpose. You can adapt your message to their mission.

For speaking in the classroom, the Internet offers considerable information about the characteristics of the first-year class; attitudes, beliefs, and practices of beginning college students; and even the way students spend their time. Many universities provide a deep

study of their students that goes beyond surface information, such as the ratio of males to females and the number of international students. For example, Stephens Point University in Wisconsin analyzes its entering class to come up with such interesting details as the fact that a much larger percentage of female students use social networking than do males but substantially more males play computer games. At many schools, the registrar includes detailed information on the university's website about how many students work, students' scores on standardized entrance tests, the highest education level achieved by their families, and much more. The Internet can be a source of information to help you know your classroom audience.

THE QUESTIONNAIRE

A more formal way to collect data on which you can base inferences is to ask your audience to fill out a **questionnaire** consisting of written questions developed to obtain demographic and attitudinal information.

questionnaire

A set of written questions developed to obtain demographic and attitudinal information.

Finding Demographic Characteristics

An important step in the process of speech preparation is discovering the audience's demographic characteristics. The term *demographics* means "the characteristics of the people." **Demographic analysis** is the collection and interpretation of data about the characteristics of people: name, age, sex, hometown, year in school, race, major subject, religion, and organizational affiliations. By describing the audience in detail, demographic information can reveal to public speakers the extent to which they will have to adapt themselves and their topics to their listeners.

demographic analysis

The collection and interpretation of data about the characteristics of people.

Seasoned public speakers usually rely heavily on demographic information. Politicians send staff ahead to find out how many blue-collar workers, faithful party members, older adults, union members, and hecklers they are likely to encounter. They consult opinion polls, population studies, and reliable persons in the area to discover the nature of a prospective audience. Conducting a demographic analysis of your class can serve a similar purpose—analysis will help you design a speech better adapted to your audience.

The groups to which your audience members belong, for instance, can signal support for or hostility toward your topic. How can you learn about these groups? Bumper stickers you observe on students' cars can signal your audience's attitudes about gun control, abortion, and political parties. In the classroom, jackets or shirts with slogans, Christian crosses, a Star of David, a Muslim hijab, sorority or fraternity letters, ethnic dress, a VFW or American Legion or Rotary pin, a Harley-Davidson jacket, telltale tattoos—many signs such as these indicate memberships that may also reflect attitudes about topics.

Levi wanted to deliver a persuasive speech on joining a fraternity, so he asked before class one day how many students in the class belonged to a sorority or fraternity. Nobody did. He knew from the outset that he had no support in the audience, but he also knew that he had selected a topic that required persuasion to change the audience's mind about joining fraternities and sororities. He started his speech by addressing some issues that people do not like about Greek organizations: hazing, drinking, and cost. He did not manage to get anyone to join a Greek house as a result of his persuasive effort, but his arguments did make his audience review and possibly revise their thinking about the value of Greek organizations when they found out that a high percentage of business leaders had been in such organizations when they were in college. Levi just asked one question of his audience before class; you can do the same or develop a very brief

questionnaire. You can gather and summarize demographic information from questions similar to the following:

- | | |
|--|---|
| <p>____1. I am</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> a. a first-year student b. a sophomore c. a junior d. a senior | <p>____2. I am</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> a. 17–21 years old b. 22–35 years old c. 36–45 years old d. over 45 |
| <p>____3. I am</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> a. single b. married c. divorced or separated d. widowed | <p>____4. I have</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> a. no children b. one child c. two children d. more than two children |

The audience members do not have to identify themselves by name to provide this information. Keeping the questionnaires anonymous encourages honest answers and does not reduce the value of the information.

Finding Attitudes, Beliefs, and Values

You can also use questionnaires to discern audience attitudes, beliefs, and values on an issue before giving the speech. An **attitude** is a predisposition to respond favorably or unfavorably to a person, an object, an idea, or an event. Attitudes are regarded as quite stable and often difficult to change. You can assess the attitudes of audience members through questionnaires, by careful observation, or even by asking the right questions. If your audience shares many attitudes, beliefs, and values, your audience analysis may be easy. For example, a speech about safe sex would be heard in some colleges with as much excitement as a speech on snails; however, at other colleges even guest speakers are not allowed on campus to talk about that subject.⁴ Attitudes toward politics, sexual preference, religion, drugs, and even work vary in different geographic areas and cultures. Regardless of the purpose of your speech, the attitudes of audience members will make a difference in the appropriateness of your topic and the way you present it. For this reason effective public speakers learn as much as possible about audience attitudes before they speak. Some examples of attitudes follow:

Antigovernment	Pro-business	Pro-conservation
Anti-gun control	Pro-green	Pro-technology
Antipollution	Pro-choice	Pro-diversity
Anti-immigration	Pro-life	Antirefugee
Pro-animal rights	Antitax	Pro-free trade

A **belief** is a conviction. Beliefs are usually considered more enduring than attitudes, but our attitudes often spring from our beliefs. Your belief in healthy eating habits may lead to a negative attitude toward overeating and obesity and a positive attitude toward balanced meals and nutrition. Your audience's beliefs make a difference in how they respond to your speech. They may believe in upward mobility through higher education, in higher pay through hard work, or in social welfare. On the other hand, they may not believe in any of these ideas. Beliefs are like anchors to which our attitudes are attached. To discover the beliefs of an audience, you need to ask questions and to observe carefully. Some examples of beliefs follow:

Hard work pays off.	Good people will go to heaven.
Taxes are too high.	Work comes before play.
Anyone can get rich.	Government should be small.
Education pays.	Wickedness will be punished.

attitude

A predisposition to respond favorably or unfavorably to a person, an object, an idea, or an event.

belief

A conviction; often thought to be more enduring than an attitude and less enduring than a value.

Table 3 Ranking Values

Rank five of the following values in their order of importance to you. If you can persuade some of your classmates, or the entire class, to do this as well, you will have information that will help you prepare your speech.

- | | | |
|------------------------|-------------------|--------------|
| _____ Wisdom | _____ Wealth | _____ Fame |
| _____ A World at Peace | _____ Security | _____ Health |
| _____ Freedom | _____ Fulfillment | _____ Love |
| _____ Equality | _____ Education | _____ Faith |

How does your ranking compare with those of your classmates? What other values might help you with your speech?

Knowing your audience’s beliefs about your topic can be a valuable aid in informing and persuading them.

A **value** is a deeply rooted belief that governs our attitude about something. Both beliefs and attitudes can be traced to a value we hold. Learned from childhood through the family, religion, school, and many other sources, values are often so much a foundation for the rest of what we believe and know that we do not question them. Sometimes we remain unaware of our primary values until they clash. For example, a person might have an unquestioned belief that every individual has the right to be and do whatever he or she wishes—basic values of individuality and freedom—until it comes to sexuality. Table 3 shows one method for ranking values.

You can collect attitudinal information in at least three ways. One way is to ask questions that place audience members in identifiable groups, as these questions do:

- _____ 5. I am
 - a. active in organizations
 - b. not active in organizations
- _____ 6. I see myself as
 - a. conservative
 - b. liberal
 - c. independent
- _____ 7. I see myself as
 - a. strongly religious
 - b. moderately religious
 - c. not religious

A second method of gaining attitudinal information is to ask people to rank values, such as hard work, higher

value
A deeply rooted belief that governs our attitude about something.

engaging diversity

Dangerous Speech Project

Susan Benesch, a human-rights lawyer at Harvard University, founded the Dangerous Speech Project to study dangerous speech and ways to counteract it. More specifically, the project works to identify inflammatory language that can motivate groups to violence. The Dangerous Speech Project contends that incendiary public speech increases steadily before outbreaks of mass violence and is found in many languages, cultures, and religions. Part of the mission of the project is to distinguish “dangerous” speech from other forms of distasteful and offensive language that typically do not give rise to violence.

Benesch uses five contextual elements that form the *Dangerous Speech Framework* for identifying dangerous speech:

1. The *speech* takes place in a social or historical context rife with violence—for example, long-standing struggles for scarce resources.
2. The *audience* has grievances or fears that a speaker uses to his or her advantage.
3. The *speaker* is highly influential and charismatic.
4. The *speech* is clearly understandable as a call to violence.
5. The *speaker* employs an influential medium—typically radio or television.

A major goal of the Dangerous Speech Project is to find the best ways to prevent violence. To do so, the project works not only to make audiences less motivated to respond with violence but also to diminish the use of dangerous speech in a way that protects freedom of expression.

Sources: Eler, A. (2015, March). How Facebook is taking on “dangerous speech:” The social network aims to tamp down violent incitement in Myanmar. *Readwrite* (<http://readwrite.com/2015/03/03/facebook-myanmar-dangerous-speech>). What is dangerous speech? (n.d.). Dangerous Speech Project [website] (www.dangerousspeech.org/the-dangerous-speech-project-preventing-mass-violence/).

For each word or phrase, indicate your attitude toward it by determining how strongly you favor or disfavor it.

	Strongly favor	Mildly favor	Neutral	Mildly disfavor	Strongly disfavor
Government bailouts of business	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Unions' right to collective bargaining	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Immigration policies	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Employer-sponsored childcare	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Military spending	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Medical marijuana	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Figure 2

Sample attitudinal scale. Compile data that indicate the attitudes within your class on one of these topics. What does this information tell you about how to approach your audience about this topic?

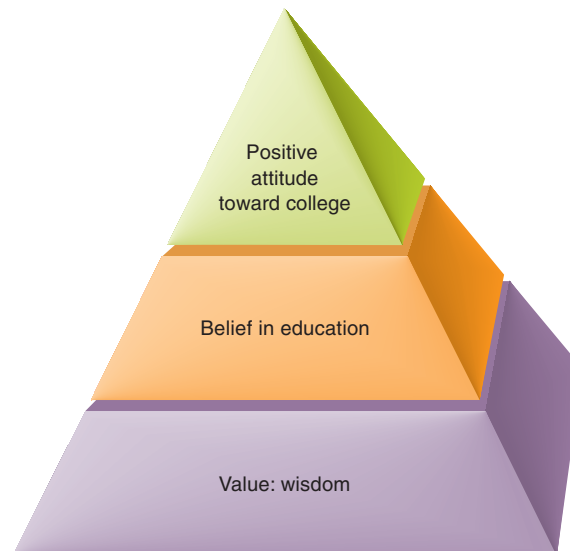
education, high pay, and security, using a scale like table 3. People's ranking of their values can provide additional information about their attitudes and beliefs.

The third method of collecting data about people's attitudes is to list word concepts that reveal attitudes and then ask respondents to assess their attitudes toward these specific issues, such as by using an attitudinal scale like the one in figure 2. The reactions to these and similar words or phrases can provide information that will help you approach your audience successfully. For example, if most persons in your audience are neutral to mildly favorable toward taxing tobacco, then your speech advocating higher tobacco taxes could be designed to move their attitudes from mildly favorable to strongly favorable. If the responses are negative, then you may have to work just to move your audience closer to a mildly unfavorable attitude or toward neutrality. Check out your own attitudes toward some word concepts in figure 2.

The values your audience members hold and the order in which they rank them can provide important clues about their attitudes and beliefs. A speaker who addresses an audience without knowing its members' values is taking a risk that can be avoided through careful audience analysis. The relationships among attitudes, beliefs, and values are illustrated in figure 3.

Figure 3

Relationships among attitudes, beliefs, and values.



sizing things up

Evaluating Topics

Brainstorming and eventually selecting an effective speech topic begins with a thorough self-assessment of your own interests and knowledge. Below you will find several topics followed by pairs of opposing adjectives arranged on a scale, or continuum. Check the space on the continuum that best represents your opinion of each topic's appropriateness as a subject for you to speak about. The space closest to "interesting," for example, represents "extremely interesting," and the space in the middle of each pair stands for "neutral." This exercise has no right or wrong answers, but if your teacher approves, you can compare your answers with those of others in your class. You might learn something about your captive audience's attitudes in the process. For additional information, refer to the guide for interpreting your responses that appears at the end of this chapter.

1. Politics

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad
 Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

2. The Environment

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad
 Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

3. The Economy

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad
 Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

4. Education

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad

Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

5. Health

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad
 Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

6. Technology

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad
 Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

7. Diversity

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad
 Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

8. Religion

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad
 Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

9. Interpersonal conflict

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad
 Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

10. Poverty

Interesting () () () () () Uninteresting
 Good () () () () () Bad
 Confident () () () () () Not Confident
 Relevant () () () () () Irrelevant

Adapt to the Audience

Audience analysis yields information about your listeners that enables you to adapt yourself and your message to that audience. A speech is not imposed on a collection of listeners; a message is negotiated between a speaker and an audience and is designed to inform, entertain, inspire, teach, or persuade that audience. This negotiation is based on your analysis of your audience.

ADAPTING YOURSELF

In public speaking you also have to adjust to information about the audience. Just as a college senior preparing for a job interview adapts to an interviewer in dress, manner,

communicating creatively

Delivering a Provocative Speech

To engage your audience, you must deliver a provocative speech. Public speaking coach Susan Trivers suggests that provocative speakers do the following:

- *They challenge the audience.* Provocative speakers challenge their audience to consider doing things tomorrow that have some risks but also appropriate rewards. For example, rather than just telling the audience that the state of math education is cause for serious concern, provocative speakers ask the audience to take risks to make change happen.
- *They create imaginative scenarios.* Provocative speakers create hypothetical or factual narratives about the struggles and victories of people that relate to their topic. Using vivid language and specific names and places rather than abstract terms allows the audience to empathize and feel connected to the topic. To remain ethical, you should not make up facts or lie about your personal experiences.
- *They help the audience connect the topic to their lives.* Provocative speakers frame the action they want the audience to engage in as a metaphor, such as framing the task like a sports competition or reality TV competition. When speakers use metaphors, they invite the audience to recognize that they (as audience members) are capable of connecting the metaphor to their real-life situations. This creates a feeling of empowerment and connection for the audience.

Trivers believes that audiences are always hoping they will be engaged when they listen to a presentation, but in reality this rarely happens. You'll know you've delivered a provocative speech when the audience argues with you, attempts to engage you in debate, or crowds around you afterward to share their ideas.

Source: Trivers, S. G. (2013). The provocative speech is just what the audience craves (www.greatspeakingcoach.com/2013/10/the-provocative-speech-is-just-what-the-audience-craves.html).

and language, a public speaker prepares for an audience by adapting to its expectations. How you look, how you behave, and what you say should be carefully tailored to your audience.

ADAPTING YOUR LANGUAGE

The language you use in your speech, as well as your gestures, movements, and even facial expressions, should be adapted to your audience. Does your audience analysis indicate that your language should be conversational, formal, cynical, or technical? Does it suggest that your listeners like numbers and statistics? Do your observations indicate that you should pace the stage or remain behind the lectern? Should you avoid taboo words in your speech, lest you alienate your group, or will the audience respond positively to controversial language?

ADAPTING YOUR TOPIC

Public speakers should be permitted to speak on nearly any topic; after all, the First Amendment provides some protection for free speech. But practical considerations may lead you to avoid certain topics, which will typically be unique to specific situations and contexts. For instance, you would almost certainly never speak about how to create biological weapons or commit financial fraud.

Of course, the right to speak on nearly any topic brings with it a respon-

sibility to adapt the way you approach your subject, given the audience to which you are speaking. Using audience analysis, you must figure out how to best approach your topic to meet your audience's needs. You may adjust your language, visual resources, supporting evidence, or even the points you make during the presentation. For example, suppose you want to speak in favor of physician-assisted suicide, and your audience analysis indicates that the majority of your listeners are opposed to it. You need not conclude that the topic is inappropriate. You may, however, adapt to the members of your audience by starting with a position closer to theirs. Your initial step might be to make audience members feel less comfortable about their present position, so that they are more prepared to hear your views.

ADAPTING YOUR PURPOSE AND GOAL

You should also adapt the purpose of your speech to your audience. Teachers often ask students to state the purpose of a speech—what do you want your audience to know,



- The public speaker must consider different opinions among audience members that reflect different values.

© AP Images/Seth Perlman

understand, or do? At first you might think your purpose should be to persuade your audience to save money by buying their clothing at outlet stores. But you discover through your audience analysis that most of your classmates already buy clothing at the outlet stores. So, you adapt your purpose. You change your purpose to an informative speech that reveals which outlet stores sell quality merchandise instead of overstocked items from their retail stores.⁵

The **immediate purpose** of your speech is what you want listeners to take away with them. It is linked to a larger goal, the end purpose you have in mind, or your **long-range goal**. Some examples will illustrate the difference. First are examples for an informative speech:

Immediate purpose: After listening to this speech, the audience should be able to identify three properties of the most advanced televisions available today.

Long-range goal: To increase the number of people who will choose wisely the next time they replace or purchase a television set.

Here are examples for a persuasive speech:

Immediate purpose: After listening to my speech, the audience should be able to describe the low nutritional value of two popular junk foods.⁶

Long-range goal: To dissuade listeners from eating junk food.

As these examples show, an immediate purpose has four essential features. First, it is highly specific. Second, it includes the phrase *should be able to*. Third, it uses an action verb, such as *state*, *identify*, *report*, *name*, *list*, *describe*, *explain*, *show*, or *reveal*. Fourth, it is stated from the viewpoint of the audience. Stated differently, the purpose is based on what you want to accomplish as a speaker, but how you communicate your purpose must be audience-centered. Your immediate purpose moves audience members toward a long-range goal.

In this section on adapting to your audience you learned that you do not have to change yourself or your position on an issue, but you can present yourself and your arguments in ways that are more likely to result in success. You learned that even the words you choose are strategic; that is, you select your words with care, so that they convince and persuade rather than offend. You can shape your topic without giving up your integrity by providing information where needed and by persuading without risking

immediate purpose

A highly specific statement using “should be able to” plus an action verb to reveal the purpose from the audience’s point of view.

long-range goal

The larger goal or end purpose you have in mind for your presentation.

a hostile audience response. Finally, you aim for some immediate effects that are possible in a brief presentation, knowing that you have a long-range goal in mind as well.

New media and cutting-edge technology have already made you an expert of sorts in audience analysis. You have a Facebook profile that attracts people you like, who become your friends. You have a cell phone so smart that its GPS always knows where you are, and its instant-messaging feature allows for quick words among friends, colleagues, and relatives. Even a blog is a site for creating messages to attract an audience. You are already sizing up others to become part of your “audience”—or not. You can use new media and new technology to sharpen your skill in audience analysis by considering how Facebook and blogs invite you to present both yourself and your message to an audience. You might be a party animal on Facebook or a political junkie on a blog, but just as in public speaking, you are adapting yourself and your message for others.

In this chapter you have learned that topic selection and audience analysis are bonded together because whatever topic you speak about becomes a message whose successful transmission depends on how well you adapt to the audience. You find appropriate vital topics to talk about by considering both what you know and what the audience needs to know. You learned four methods of audience analysis and the various ways to adapt your presentation for an audience.

These skills of knowing what to talk about and how to talk about it are valuable well beyond the public speaking classroom. These skills are the basics for people who are successful at sales, management, and leadership.

be ready... for what's next

Does Your Topic Fit Your Audience?

This chapter began with Stephen Bonsi delivering a high-level speech on economics to an indifferent audience. His speech would have been more successful if he had simplified his topic and explained complex concepts. Stephen was correct when he selected a vital topic, but he needed to adapt his topic to his particular audience. He could have used very simple economics to demonstrate how the wealthy have gained, how the middle class has diminished, and how the poor have grown in number. Instead, he mistakenly gave a sophisticated and jargon-prone presentation to a room full of novices who barely understood the topic. Also, Stephen could have created a more engaging presentation by making his speech more proactive using the three characteristics you read about in the Communicating Creatively feature box.

To check the appropriateness of your own topic for your audience, answer the following questions about an upcoming speech you have in one of your classes or as part of your job.

- Is the topic you selected a vital topic?
- Is the topic you selected one in which you can arouse audience interest?
- Do you know more about the topic than most people in your audience?
- Can you translate what you know for people who do not know about the topic?
- Can you figure out where the audience stands now on your topic?
- Can you determine how much more you should inform the audience about the topic?
- Can you determine how much change to ask of the audience on this topic?

The answers to these questions about the link between your topic and your audience can lead you to a successful presentation.

Chapter Review & Study Guide

Summary

In this chapter, you learned the following:

1. Select a topic appropriate for you and your audience.
 - Try brainstorming and surveying your interests.
 - Assess your knowledge and commitment to the topic.
 - Consider the age of the topic and audience.
 - Determine the topic's importance to you and your audience.
 - Recognize the special challenges for ELLs in topic selection.
2. Practice narrowing a topic to save time and energy and to increase relevance to the audience.
3. Employ observation, inference, research, and questionnaires to analyze your audience.
 - Observe your audience for demographic and membership cues.
 - Draw direct and indirect inferences about your audience.
 - Research your audience with inside informants and the Internet.
 - Use a questionnaire to assess attitudes, beliefs, and values.
4. Recognize how to adapt your topic, yourself, your language, and your purpose and goal in public speaking.
 - Any topic can be adapted to a particular audience.
 - Without compromising yourself, you can adapt yourself to an audience.
 - Your language choices must be adapted to the specific audience.
 - Your purpose depends heavily on what you can accomplish with a particular audience.
 - Your long-range goal also depends on where the audience stands on an issue.

Key Terms

Attitude
Audience analysis
Belief
Brainstorming
Commitment

Demographic analysis
Direct inference
Immediate purpose
Indirect inference
Inference

Long-range goal
Questionnaire
Value

Study Questions

1. What is one basic strategy to keep in mind when selecting a topic for presentation?
 - a. Take a lot of time in choosing a topic.
 - b. Begin with a subject you already know.
 - c. Select a topic you know nothing about.
 - d. Choose a topic that does not affect you personally.
2. After choosing a topic, what should you do?
 - a. Evaluate the importance of your topic.
 - b. Determine how much you and your audience know about the topic.
 - c. Evaluate your commitment to the topic.
 - d. All the above are correct.
3. Why is narrowing your topic important?
 - a. to save time and effort
 - b. to reduce the depth of the topic
 - c. to reduce your bias about the topic
 - d. to increase the length of your speech
4. When you investigate the audience's demographics, interests, and concerns, you are
 - a. brainstorming.
 - b. surveying your interests.
 - c. analyzing the audience.
 - d. creating a captive audience.
5. Which level of audience analysis includes collecting data about the characteristics of people?
 - a. audience type
 - b. audience interest in the topic
 - c. audience's attitudes, beliefs, and values
 - d. demographic analysis

connect

To maximize your study time, check out **CONNECT** to access the SmartBook study module for this chapter, watch videos, and explore other resources.

6. A deeply rooted belief that affects how we act toward an idea or a concept is a(n)
 - a. attitude.
 - b. mood.
 - c. value.
 - d. thought.
7. A method of audience analysis that draws tentative generalizations based on some evidence is
 - a. observation.
 - b. inference.
 - c. a questionnaire.
 - d. a survey.
8. If you ask people to rank concepts in order of importance or you ask them questions that place individuals into identifiable groups, you are
 - a. conducting a questionnaire.
 - b. brainstorming.
 - c. narrowing.
 - d. inferring.
9. Which method of analysis requires using your senses to interpret information about the audience?
 - a. involvement
 - b. value
 - c. judgment
 - d. observation
10. Which is *not* true of immediate purposes?
 - a. They are highly specific.
 - b. They include the phrase *should be able to*.
 - c. They use an action verb.
 - d. They are stated from the viewpoint of the speaker.

Answers:

1. (b); 2. (d); 3. (a); 4. (c); 5. (d); 6. (c); 7. (b); 8. (a); 9. (d); 10. (d)

Critical Thinking

1. Choose a broad topic, and then narrow it by creating your own concept map (see figure 2). At what point do the topics become too specific to be discussed in depth? Which are still too broad for a brief presentation? Choose a few that are just right.
2. You are a white person asked to give a speech to a service club about race relations in the workplace. You

expected an all-white audience, but on your arrival you see that at least half the audience consists of people of color. Using the chapter's last section on adaptation, write down how, if at all, you might adapt yourself, your topic, and your purpose to this unexpected reality. Would your answers be different if you were a person of color facing this audience?

Sizing Things Up Scoring and Interpretation

Evaluating Topics

Personal inventories are typically qualitative in nature; that is, you write down topics about which you are interested or knowledgeable. The scale created for this chapter provides a quantitative way of assessing interest in 10 broad topic areas. Results of this survey can be used in two ways. First, you may select a topic area in which you score very high and use that as a guide for generating speech topics. Second, if you average responses from your classmates, you can use this information as a simple audience-analysis survey.

To score this survey, notice that each topic has a four-item semantic-differential scale. Rather than writing or

circling numbers, simply check a space to indicate how strongly a particular adjective represents your views toward the general topic. From left to right on each semantic-differential item, score responses as a 5, 4, 3, 2, or 1 based on which space you checked. Thus, higher values will indicate more positive perceptions toward that topic. Sum scores for the four items under each topic area to achieve a total score between 4 and 20. Values closer to 20 indicate more positive perceptions toward that topic.

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